Day 45 - Pretty River, Russ McConnell, Pretty River Access

Bruce Trail side-trail plan (dog-friendly, max ~8 mi) · Blue Mountains section · hike 54 · Pretty River Valley Provincial Park

9.6 km / 6.0 mi	~3.0 h	2.8 km new	109 min
total walking	hiking, plus stops	side trail covered	drive each way, Sat 7 am

Park (P): Parking area located 380 m north of the main Trail crossing on Pretty River Rd. Google Maps. **Free**

Navigate: import *day45_hike054.gpx* into Gaia GPS. The track is the whole route in walking order, and the J waypoints match the directions below.

Side trails covered: Pretty River Side Trail (1.4 km); Russ McConnell Side Trail (0.9 km); Pretty River Access Side Trail (0.5 km)

Route map



What to expect

- **Parking:** A designated lot 380 m north of the trail crossing on Pretty River Rd. Parking on the road itself is not allowed. The park is non-operating with no washrooms.
- **Pretty River Access Side Trail:** Climbs right away, through a cedar thicket with tightly packed trunks.
- **Pretty River Side Trail:** Passes Sundown Lake, then tops out and descends with some good views. Lower down, a river has several small waterfalls and a few short boardwalks. Near the end there is a spot to wade, which hikers say dogs enjoy.
- **Main Bruce Trail:** Hilly, with steep grades in places. Parts were damaged in a windstorm, so expect fallen trees. The town's trail map marks the highest point on the Bruce Trail (540 m) nearby.
- **Russ McConnell Side Trail:** A loop of under 1 km off the main trail. No details of its terrain were found.

- **Plants:** Watch for poison ivy and giant hogweed, which can cause severe burns. The town asks that pets stay leashed.

Parking options

No other official Bruce Trail parking lies within about 1 km of this route. If you need to stop early, turn back the way you came; the GPS track records what you covered, and the website shows what is left.

Parking costs were checked in October 2026 from operator websites and Bruce Trail Conservancy data; prices and booking rules change, so check before you go.

Turn-by-turn

km	mi	Directions
0.0	0.0	Start at the parking: Parking area located 380 m north of the main Trail crossing on Pretty River Rd. Head north on the blue-blazed Pretty River Access Side Trail. The next 0.2 km follows an unopened road allowance (rough track, no traffic).
0.5	0.3	J1: Continue straight onto the white-blazed main Bruce Trail, heading south. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off ahead.)
1.3	0.8	J2: Turn sharp right onto the blue-blazed Pretty River Side Trail, heading north. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off on your left.)
2.7	1.7	J3: Continue straight onto the white-blazed main Bruce Trail, heading north-west. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off on your left.)
3.3	2.1	J4: Junction. Continue straight to stay on the main Bruce Trail, heading north. (the blue-blazed John Haigh Side Trail goes off on your left.)
3.9	2.4	J5: Turn left onto the blue-blazed Russ McConnell Side Trail, heading north-west. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off ahead.)
4.8	3.0	J6: End of the Russ McConnell Side Trail. Turn around and retrace your steps.
5.7	3.6	J5: Turn right onto the white-blazed main Bruce Trail, heading south-west. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off on your left.)
6.3	3.9	J4: Junction. Continue straight to stay on the main Bruce Trail, heading south. (the blue-blazed John Haigh Side Trail goes off on your right.)
6.9	4.3	J3: Continue straight onto the blue-blazed Pretty River Side Trail, heading east. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off ahead.)
8.3	5.1	J2: Turn sharp left onto the white-blazed main Bruce Trail, heading north-east. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off ahead.)
9.1	5.7	J1: Continue straight onto the blue-blazed Pretty River Access Side Trail, heading north. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off on your right.)
9.5	5.9	Heads-up: The next 0.2 km follows an unopened road allowance (rough track, no traffic).
9.6	6.0	Back at the parking. Hike complete.

Distances and junctions are computed from the Bruce Trail Conservancy's trail data (Bruce County GIS). Left/right is calculated from the trail geometry. Use it as a guide, follow the blazes, and check the Conservancy's trail-change notices before you go. Dogs must be leashed everywhere on the Bruce Trail. Trail descriptions draw on onX, the Town of The Blue Mountains trail map and Ontario Nature Trails.